

CHARLEMAGNE



ON CHRISTMAS DAY, 800, a remarkable emperor was crowned in Europe. His name was Charles, and he was known as Charles the Great, or Charlemagne. He was king of the Franks of northern France, and managed to create a large empire after the turmoil that followed the fall of Rome. Under Charlemagne, Europe enjoyed a period of peace and unity it had not had for 400 years. Yet the king was illiterate and brutal, and held his empire together only by force.

Carolingian Empire

In order to control his vast territory, Charlemagne installed bishops and counts in each district to run both the religious and the secular affairs of the empire. He supported an educational system based on the monasteries, and introduced a legal system that owed much to the Roman Empire.

Extent of the empire

By the time of his death in 814, Charlemagne controlled an empire that stretched from Hamburg in northern Germany to south of Rome, and from the Atlantic Ocean to the River Danube. He converted the warlike Saxons to Christianity, and subdued the Lombard kingdom of northern Italy.

Charlemagne's realm

- Frankish lands, 714
- Adjoining territories
- Empire of Charlemagne



Early life

Charlemagne was born in Aachen in what is now Germany in about 742. He was the oldest son of Pepin, king of the Franks, and inherited his kingdom in 768, jointly with his brother, Carloman. When Carloman died in 771, Charlemagne became sole ruler of the Franks.

Marches

In order to protect his vast empire, Charlemagne established marches, or buffer zones, along the southern border with Muslim Spain and the eastern border with the various Germanic tribes. Troops of armoured horsemen patrolled the marches to protect the empire against raids across its lengthy borders.



Charlemagne used cavalrymen to protect the borders of his empire.

A new Roman emperor

In the 8th century, the Pope's security as head of the Christian church was threatened by the Lombards from northern Italy. In 773, Charlemagne conquered Lombardy. To recognize his support, the Pope gave Charlemagne the title of Emperor of the Romans.



Coin of Charlemagne

Coronation

Charlemagne visited Rome in 800, and Pope Leo III crowned him and paid him homage. For the first time since the Roman Empire, Christian Europe was united, and the idea of a Holy Roman Empire was born.



Dark Ages

For centuries, historians talked of the time after the fall of the Roman Empire as the Dark Ages. But we now know that the period was a time of great achievement in scholarship and the arts. This activity reached its height under Charlemagne.

Aachen

At his capital of Aachen (Aix-la-Chapelle), Charlemagne created a brilliant court where art flourished. He built a vast palace and chapel which some visitors thought was like a "second Rome".



Scholarship

Scholars came from all over Europe to Aachen to work for Charlemagne. They rescued classical Latin learning from oblivion, and ensured that future generations could learn about the Roman Empire.



Double-edged blade

Socket to attach shaft

Carolingian spearhead



CHARLEMAGNE

c.742 Born in Aachen.

768 Succeeds to Frankish Empire with his brother Carloman.

771 Takes sole control of empire.

772 Begins conquest of Saxony in northern Germany.

773 Subdues Lombards in Italy.

778 Conquers Bavaria in southern Germany.

795 Establishes Spanish march to protect his kingdom from Muslim Spain.

800 Crowned emperor of the Romans by Pope Leo III.

814 Dies and is buried at Aachen.

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